MANIPUR

TRIGGER WARNING

A party I-card should be the most natural objet d'art to adorn election season. But when the name on it is that of controversial ex-cop **Thounaojam Brinda**, and the party is the ruling BJP, bet on it stirring a hornet's nest in Manipur. After the visual went viral, the BJP denied her induction—and Brinda stayed tight-lipped too. Last October, she had quit the police force with a fusillade against Chief Minister N. Biren Singh for not letting her go all-out against drug trafficking. Politics beckoned, she said, but her choice of party would be "decided by the people". That manoeuvre ending with a BJP ticket will be an irony more delicious than a fiery Manipuri eromba. Adding more spice is talk of a rift in the family. Her father-in-law is former United National Liberation Front (UNLF) chairman R.K. Meghen 'Sanayaima'. Needless to say, he's not exactly chuffed with this proximity to India's "multi-party democracy"!





UTTAR PRADESH

SA RE GA MA... BA!

One thing about that quintessential Indian spirit: it knows no curfew or quarantine. Last week, we were fretting that the EC ban on physical rallies—now extended till January 22—may take away much of the colour from this poll campaign. We spoke too soon! The festive air that surrounds Indian elections may have been forced out of the public squares, but this is 2022...and even UP's kasbas and mohallas know how to jive online. All parties have turned to music to create a good vibe around themselves. From big stars to local artistes and folk singers, they're all putting out ditties and catchy song videos.

One particular video exchange caught on so much, it made national headlines. The BJP's Gorakhpur MP Ravi Kishan—one of the

RAVI KISHAN: THOSE WHO SAY 'AYE'

"Je kabo na rahal oo ab ba
Je kabo na rahal oo ab ba
Yogi ke sarkar ba
Vikas ke bahaar ba
Sadkan ke jaal ba
Kaam bemisaal ba
Apraadhi ke jail ba
Bijli relam rel ba
Corona gayil haar ba
UP mein sab ba"